originates from the days of the British Raj. Different Indian leaders have seen the region stretching from the Gulf to South-East Asia as important to India, just as the officials of the Raj saw it, albeit with a different focus. For the British, India was the nucleus of an overseas empire, a base from which they could rule, control and defend lands distant from the British homeland.

After Independence, Nehru focused on Asia where he sought to act as leader of a vast continent that was just emerging from Western colonial rule. He did not think in security terms, at least until the war with China in 1962. In Nehru's view, bilateral treaties of friendship and peace with the three northern Himalayan kingdoms – Bhutan, Nepal and Sikkim – and an offer of a no-war pact to Pakistan[19] was enough to deal with South Asia, freeing him to seek prominence on the Asian and global stage.

The notion of the subcontinent as India's backyard attained centrality under Indira Gandhi. Under her leadership, India's goal in its immediate vicinity was no longer simply to protect India's security and strategic interests; India would henceforth also be interested in any incidents in the neighbourhood that had or could have an impact on India. The Indira doctrine was a South Asian version of America's well known Monroe doctrine. As writer Ashok Kapur states, Indian leaders, beginning with Indira, wanted India to be 'the only security manager in South Asia' and sought to reduce the role of external actors – primarily the United States and the Soviet Union – and their ability to influence regional politics 'to a level of economic and technological assistance that would not encourage Pakistan to pursue its irredentist claims.'[20] India was not always able to achieve this policy as Pakistan continually sought parity with its larger neighbour, drawing the United States into the region as its ally.[21]

Under Indira, India sought acknowledgement as South Asia's pre-eminent power, was willing to flex its muscle to assert its pre-eminence and did not want outside powers to involve themselves in the region's affairs without India's approval. The Indira doctrine manifested itself most